Culture of Kerala

Kerala is a southern most state of India. Kerala can largely trace its non-prehistoric cultural genesis to its membership (around the 3rd century CE) in a vaguely-defined historical region known as *Thamizhagom* — a land defined by a common Tamil culture and encompassing the Chera, Chola, and Pandya kingdoms. At that time, the music, dance, language (first *Dravida Bhasha* — "Dravidian language"[1] — then Tamil), and *Sangam* (a vast corpus of Tamil literature composed between 1,500–2,000 years ago) found in Kerala were all similar to that found in the rest of *Thamizhagom* (today's Tamil Nadu). Later, Keralite culture was elaborated upon by centuries of contact with overseas lands — yet all through this time, its cultural heritage remained defined by its antiquity and organic continuity.[2]

Performing arts

Native traditions of classical performing arts include *koodiyattom*, a form of Sanskrit drama or theatre and a UNESCO-designated Human Heritage Art. *Kathakali* (from *katha* ("story") and *kali* ("performance")) is a 500-year-old form of dance-drama that interprets ancient epics; a popularized offshoot of *kathakali* is *Kerala natanam* (developed in the 20th century by dancer Guru Gopinath). Meanwhile, *koothu* is a more light-hearted performance mode, akin to modern stand-up comedy; an ancient art originally confined to temple sanctuaries, it was later popularized by Mani Madhava Chakyar. Other Keralite performing arts include *mohiniyaattam* ("dance of the enchantress"), which is a type of graceful choreographed dance performed by women and accompanied by musical vocalizations. *Thullal*, *padayani*, and *theyyam* are other important Keralite arts.

Kerala also has several tribal and folk art forms.For example, Kummattikali is the famous colorful mask-dance of South Malabar, performed during the festival of Onam. The Kannyar Kali dances (also known as Desathukali) are fast moving, militant dances attuned to rhythmic devotional folk songs and asuravadyas. Also important are various performance genres that are Islam- or Christianity-themed. These include *oppana*, which is widely popular among Keralite Muslims and is native to Malabar. *Oppana* incorporates group dance accompanied by the beat of rhythmic hand clapping and *ishal* vocalizations.

Margam Kali is one of the ancient round group dance of Kerala practiced by Saint Thomas Christians.[3]

However, many of these native art forms largely play to tourists or at youth festivals, and are not as popular among ordinary Keralites. Thus, more contemporary forms — including those heavily based on the use of often risqué and politically incorrect mimicry and parody — have gained considerable mass appeal in recent years. Indeed, contemporary artists often use such modes to mock socioeconomic elites. In recent decades, Malayalam cinema, yet another mode of widely popular artistic expression, have provided a distinct and indigenous Keralite alternative to both Bollywood and Hollywood.

Music

The *ragas* and *talas* of lyrical and devotional carnatic music — another native product of South India — dominates Keralite classical musical genres. Swathi Thirunal Rama Varma, a 19th-century king of Travancore and patron and composer of music, was instrumental in popularising carnatic music in early Kerala.[4][5] Additionally, Kerala has its own native music system, *sopanam*, which is a lugubrious and step-by-step rendition of raga-based songs. It is *sopanam*, for example, that provides the background music used in *kathakali*. The wider traditional music of Kerala also includes *melam* (including the *paandi* and *panchari* variants), as style of percussive music performed at temple-centered festivals using an instrument known as the *chenda*. Up to 150 musicians may comprise the ensembles staging a given performance; each performance, in turn, may last up to four hours. *Panchavadyam* is a differing type of percussion ensemble consisting of five types of percussion instruments; these can be utilised by up to one hundred artists in certain major festivals. In addition to these, percussive music is also associated with various uniquely Keralite folk arts forms. Lastly, the popular music of Kerala — as in the rest of India — is dominated by the *filmi* music of Indian cinema.

Martial arts and sports

Kerala also has its own indigenous form of martial art — Kalarippayattu, derived from the words *kalari* ("place", "threshing floor", or "battlefield") and *payattu* ("exercise" or "practice"). Influenced by both Kerala's Brahminical past and Ayurvedic medicine, *kalaripayattu* is attributed by oral tradition to Parasurama. After some two centuries of suppression by British colonial authorities, it is now experiencing strong comeback among Keralites while also steadily gaining worldwide attention. Other popular ritual arts include *theyyam* and *poorakkali* — these originate from northern Malabar, which is the northernmost part of Kerala. Nevertheless, these have in modern times been largely supplanted by more popular sports such as cricket, kabaddi, soccer, badminton, and others. Kerala is home of the football clubs Viva Kerala and FC Kochin.

Literature

Malayalam literature is ancient in origin, and includes such figures as the 14th century Niranam poets (Madhava Panikkar, Sankara Panikkar and Rama Panikkar), whose works mark the dawn of both modern Malayalam language and indigenous Keralite poetry. The Triumvirate of poets (*Kavithrayam*: Kumaran Asan, Vallathol Narayana Menon and Ulloor S. Parameswara Iyer) are recognized for moving Keralite poetry away from archaic sophistry and metaphysics and towards a more lyrical mode. Later, such contemporary writers as Booker Prize winner Arundhati Roy (whose 1996 semi-autobiographical bestseller *The God of Small Things* is set in the Kottayam town of Ayemenem) have garnered international recognition. From 1970 to early 1990s, a lot of Malayalam Novelists and story writers contributed to the Literature of Kerala. The contributions from OV Vijayan, CV Sriraman, T Padmanabhan, Sethu, Perumbatavam Sreedharan, Kovilan have been remarkable. Significant contributions from poets and song writers such as P. Bhaskaran and ONV Kurup have influenced contemporary literature. Critics such as M Krishnan Nair have added value by providing critical analysis on the books written during the recent past.

Calendar

Kerala also has an indigenous ancient solar calendar — the Malayalam calendar — which is used in various communities primarily for timing agricultural and religious activities.

Elephants in Kerala culture

The elephants are an integral part of the daily life in Kerala. These Indian elephants are given a prestigious place in the state's culture. Elephants in Kerala are often referred to as the 'sons of the *sahya*'. The elephant is the state animal of Kerala and is featured on the emblem of the Government of Kerala.

Sarpa Kavu (Sacred Grove of the Serpent)

Sarpa Kavu (meaning *Sacred Grove of the Serpent*) is a typically small traditional grove of trees seen in the Kerala state of South India. These pristine groves usually have representations of several *Naga Devatas* (*serpent gods*), which were worshipped by the joint families or taravads . This was part of *Nagaradhana* (snake worship) which was prevalent among keralites during past centuries. It had been practised by Ezhavas, Nairs, Arayas and many other tribal, non-tribal and costal communities all over Malabar Cost in south India.

Temple Festivals

Kerala has a large number of temples. The temples celebrate annual festivals which are not only unique to the region but sometimes have features that are unique to each temple.